RIVALRY ACROSS THE NORTH SEA



Dutch men-of-war in harbor
The ship in the foreground is anchored at the entrance to a harbor, with small boats going alongside to deliver supplies. Another man-of-war is entering the harbor under sail. The scene was painted in the early 1650s about the time of the First Anglo-Dutch War.

IN THE THIRD QUARTER of the 17th century the English and the Dutch fought one another in three wars that rank among the most intensive naval struggles of all time, with many large fleet encounters and heavy loss of life on both sides. The toll of casualties was partly a result of the massive firepower deployed, with a single ship carrying a larger weight of cannon than an entire 17th-century land army, but also a consequence of the close proximity of the opposing fleets, facing one another across the southern North Sea. The Anglo-Dutch Wars forced both sides to improve their navies at every level. The wars established the importance of fighting in line and made reliance on armed merchantmen, rather than purpose-built warships, obsolescent.

COMMERCIAL WARFARE

Each of the Anglo-Dutch Wars—the first lasting from 1652 to 1654, the second from 1665 to 1667, and the third from 1672 to 1674— had its own specific origins. The third war also involved France, for once in alliance with England. But the common root of the series of conflicts lay in commercial and colonial rivalry between two maritime nations.

The Dutch were regarded as Europe's leading naval power, and their prowess at sea had enabled them to accumulate enormous wealth through the control of trade and colonies. English governments and merchants envied Dutch success and hoped by war to steal trade and colonies for themselves. Despite raiding and small-scale fighting in Africa, Asia, and the Americas, however, the decisive battles were all fought in the "Narrow Seas"—the English Channel and southern North Sea. By asserting their sovereignty over these waters, the English threatened Dutch commerce, which depended on free passage through the Narrow Seas. England had the geographical advantage in the wars, being better placed to block Dutch trade, although the conflict cut England off from essential nautical supplies from the Baltic. One geographical advantage that the Dutch enjoyed over the English was that their coastline was protected by shoals and sandbanks that provided a safe haven for their ships.

IMPROVEMENTS IN GUNNERY AND COMMAND

After the First Anglo-Dutch War had demonstrated the clear superiority of English guns and gunnery, the Dutch had to build bigger, more heavily armed ships. It was a sign

Battle of Scheveningen
The last battle of the First Anglo-Dutch War was fought off the Dutch coast in 1653. The Dutch succeeded in lifting the blockade that the English had imposed on them, but their great admiral, Maarten Tromp, lost his life in the process.

